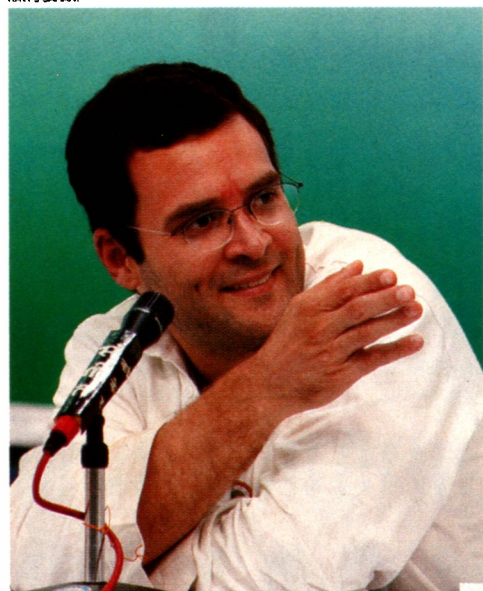
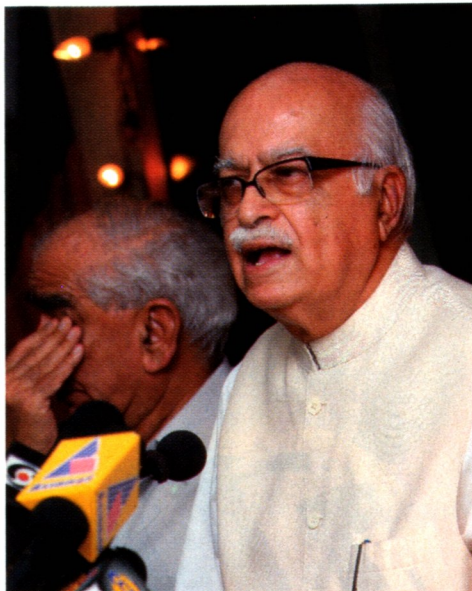


RAVI S SAHANI



SIPRA DAS



**AGE NO BAR: Rahul (left) and Advani**

## Catch 'em Young

**DELHI** It's the battle for the youth vote. Both the Congress's star campaigner and the NDA's prime ministerial candidate are gunning for the young and impressionable voter. With 72 per cent of the total population being under the age of 35 (this

includes 10 crore first-time voters), the young and the restless make a formidable votebank.

In this contest, 38-year-old Rahul Gandhi has a natural advantage over 81-year-old L.K. Advani. He has included school-children in his itinerary

along with overnight stopovers at Dalit households. Among children he loses some of his famous reserve and trades banter and hugs. He also answers questions about his marital plans; it was to a schoolgirl in Bhatinda that he confided his plans on getting married soon. When the girls swoon over his good looks, he blushes

shyly and gives them a dimpled smile.

For Advani, the task is somewhat more uphill. But his strategists are confident that they can use his experience to win over the young. He has introduced 'youthful' tools such as a website on his political thoughts. His spin masters say that Advani took one look at Barack Obama's website and said he wanted one just like his. Advani is also eyeing the college votebank. Last week he met some students at FICCI and listed a five-point agenda. Apart from the obvious education and jobs, Advani has added environment to the list.

With Advani busy crafting his Obama moment, the young voter has a wide variety of choice—from both ends of the age spectrum.

*by Priya Sahgal*

### THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

**The BJP and the Congress see the coming Assembly elections as the dry run to the general elections. Both have unanimously agreed to adjourn Parliament mid-session so that they can get on with more important things.**

### VOICES



**"Raj Thackeray is a mental case. There should be strong action against Maharashtra Navnirman Sena. It should be banned."**

Lalu Prasad Yadav, Union railway minister

**"You (the media) give so much importance to encounters and custodial deaths. They are just a small percentage as far as the entire country is concerned."**

Justice S. Rajendra Babu, National Human Rights Commission chairman

**"When the time comes, secular forces back out as they do not have the will to condemn communal forces since they are worried over losing votes of the majority community."**

Prakash Karat, CPI(M) general secretary

**"Some parties are using Batla house encounter (in Jamia Nagar) as an ATM card to debit political mileage out of their votebank. The sufferers are again the common man."**

Ravi Shankar Prasad, BJP spokesperson

**"You are remembered for what you do in Test cricket, this is the ultimate thing. Some of the greatest players have played Twenty20 but people won't remember them for that."**

Sourav Ganguly, cricketer

